before the 2019 election. The party claims support among the Nishad community of boatmen, fishermen and over a dozen sub-castes such as Bind, Mallah and Manjhi, whose traditional occupations centre around the rivers in the Gangetic belt. Founded in 2016, the party has risen in influence after joining the NDA.

Anupriya's Apna Dal (Sonelal) and the Apna Dal (K) led by her mother Krishna Patel bank on Kurmi votes, the second biggest OBC bloc in UP after the Yadavs, followed by the Rajbhars. "The Kurmis make up 7-8 per cent of UP's population. In the east, they play a big role in Ambedkar Nagar, Varanasi, Sonbhadra, Mirzapur," says Prof. Kaviraj of the political science department, Lucknow University. Intra-caste, the Gangwars have a sway in Bareilly and Pilibhit, while Vermas and Patels are strong in central and eastern UP. The BJP has given the Apna Dal(S) two seats; the SP is still finalising Apna Dal(K)'s share.

The BJP and SP accept the importance of these parties, but are annoyed with the "pressure tactics". A BJP veteran claims, "It's our *majboori* (compulsion), or the SP will take them in. We wouldn't entertain their outrageous demands otherwise." Shilp Shikha Singh, assistant professor at Lucknow's Giri Institute of Development Studies, is ambivalent about the niche parties. "Their ability to fill in the 'representational gap' is unclear. Their base remains fluid and their assertions non-ideological. They are also highly dependent on the leader, and can become ineffective if the founding figure loses connect with the community." In a curious echo, some of that's also true of the one big caste-based party whose intent still remains a riddle amid all the feverish movement of pawns in UP: Mayawati's BSP. ■



ANI

THE CIRCLE PM Modi, CM Nitish and deputy CM Samrat Choudhary in Aurangabad, Mar. 2

BIHAR

NITISH IN A SAFFRON MAZE

By Amitabh Srivastava

On March 2, a day after celebrating his 73rd birthday, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar was sharing the stage with Prime Minister Narendra Modi in Aurangabad district and sounding a bit contrite. "*Hum gayab ho gaye thhe, par ab hum phir aapke saath hain. Hum aapko ashwast karte hain, ab hum idhar-udhar hone wale nahin hain, rahenge aapke saath* (We had disappeared for a while, but now we are back with you. And I want to assure you, this time we're staying put)," he said as both of them enjoyed a laugh.

Nitish's U-turns are by now part of folklore, so a spot of self-deprecatory humour was just what the occasion needed, especially since there was a goodish chance that some old ice lingered that needed to thaw. The two leaders performed the rites of reunion perfectly: when BJP leaders welcomed Modi with a huge garland, he held out a hand to bring Nitish, too, under it.

The surface camaraderie aside, a touch of mutual wariness is not too hard to spot in the subsoil. Not a single seat in Bihar was announced in the first list of 195 candidates the BJP released the same day. With Nitish back in the fold, seat-sharing for the 40 Lok